

THE LAST FIVE ICC MULTI-NATION EVENTS SINCE THE 2007 WORLD CUP

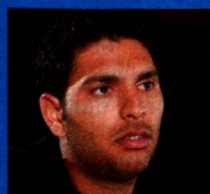
 ENGLAND	 SOUTH AFRICA	 WEST INDIES	 INDIA
—	—	—	Won the World Twenty20, 2007
Semi-finalists in the World Twenty20, 2010 and the Champions Trophy, 2009	Semi-finalists in the ICC World Cup, 2007 and semi-finalists in the World Twenty20, 2009	Semi-finalists in the World Twenty20, 2009	—
Lost in Super 8s in the World Cup, 2007; the World Twenty20 in 2007 and 2009	Knocked out from Super 8s league in the World Twenty20 in 2007 and 2010; the Champions Trophy, 2009	Knocked out from Super 8s league in the ICC World Cup, 2007; the Champions Trophy, 2009; and the World Twenty20, 2010	Knocked out from Super 8s league in the World Twenty20 in 2009 and 2010; the Champions Trophy, 2009. Failed to make Super 8s in the World Cup, 2007.

Rusty Blades

They were to lead the batting charge, but were all at sea in the West Indies



SURESH RAINA
India's man in form will from now on be scrutinised due to his struggling against the short ball.

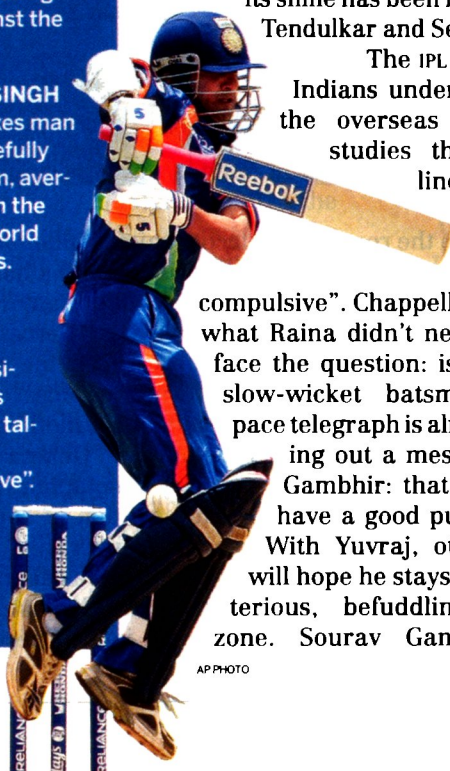


YUVRAJ SINGH
The six-sixes man is now woefully out of form, averaging 29 in the last two World Twenty20s.



ROHIT SHARMA
The opposition thinks Sharma is talented but "compulsive".

GAUTAM GAMBHIR's failures in Barbados will now pass the word around about his lack of certitude with the pull & hook.



opener Aakash Chopra says, "If there is an intent to improve, there are ways to improve even against short stuff." The core of the batting—Gautam Gambhir, Yuvraj Singh, Suresh Raina and Rohit Sharma—has an abundance of ability but have earned most of their reputations through the ODI cricket, usually against a 15-over-old ball, after its shine has been belted off by Tendulkar and Sehwag.

The IPL has helped Indians understand how the overseas opposition studies the next in line. Sharma is thought of as, "talented but compulsive". Chappell said on air what Raina didn't need was "to face the question: is he only a slow-wicket batsman?" The pace telegraph is already sending out a message about Gambhir: that he doesn't have a good pull or hook. With Yuvraj, other teams will hope he stays in his mysterious, befuddling twilight zone. Sourav Ganguly said,

"Yuvraj has to look at his game, if he doesn't keep performing for a long time, selectors will not play him on the basis of his reputation alone."

The last time India sank without a trace in the World Twenty20s, coach Gary Kirsten had asked for India players to be pulled out of the IPL before the start of a major tournament. No one in the BCCI thought it was a worthy idea because "players from all other countries are playing the same amount". The ways for India to pick itself off the mat now, says Chopra, are "ruthlessness in team selection and a re-structuring of the contracts to keep an eye on the bowling bench strength. And we shouldn't take the IPL too seriously."

Those words echo across the country. Former India paceman Javagal Srinath says, "Let's keep IPL performances right there." It means "absolutely genuine talent" must be recognised "with different and higher standards". Srinath offered an example: "The genuine quality player, like Kevin Pietersen, will switch formats, go from a not-so-successful IPL to international T20s, and succeed. The reverse is not possible." The selectors had better be taking notes. ■

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